second-largest state (after Russia), covering almost a million square kilometres and including most of the territory of today's Poland, Lithuania, Belarus and Ukraine. It lacked the information, communication and education systems necessary to hold a meaningful political conversation between Polish aristocrats, Lithuanian noblemen, Ukrainian Cossacks and Jewish rabbis spread from the Baltic Sea to the Black Sea. Its self-correcting mechanisms were also too costly, paralyzing the power of the central government. In particular, every single Sejm deputy was given the right to veto all parliamentary legislation, which led to political deadlock. The combination of a large and diverse polity with a weak centre proved fatal. The commonwealth was torn apart by centrifugal forces, and its pieces were then divided between the centralised autocracies of Russia, Austria and Prussia.

The Dutch experiment fared better. In some ways the Dutch United Provinces were even less centralised than the Polish–Lithuanian Commonwealth, since they lacked a monarch and were a union of seven autonomous provinces, which were in turn made up of self-governing towns and cities.[40] This decentralised nature is reflected in the plural form of how the country was known abroad – the Netherlands in English, Les Pays-Bas in French, Los Países Bajos in Spanish, and so on.

However, taken together the United Provinces were twenty-five times smaller in land mass than Poland–Lithuania and possessed a much better information, communication and education system that tied its constituent parts closely together.[41] The United Provinces also pioneered a new information technology with a big future. In June 1618 a pamphlet titled *Courante uyt Italien, Duytslandt &c*. appeared in Amsterdam. As its title indicated, it carried news from the Italian Peninsula, the German lands and other places. There was nothing remarkable about this particular pamphlet, except that new issues were published in the following weeks, too. They appeared regularly until 1670, when the *Courante uyt Italien, Duytslandt &c*. merged with other serial pamphlets into the *Amsterdamsche Courant*, which appeared until 1903, when it was merged into *De Telegraaf* – the Netherlands' largest newspaper to this day.[42]

The newspaper is a periodic pamphlet, and it was different from earlier one-off pamphlets because it had a much stronger self-correcting mechanism. Unlike one-off publications, a weekly or daily newspaper has a chance to correct its mistakes and an incentive to do so in order to win the